



Sofrito

COCINA BORICUA

Sofrito 101

Master the base — the one blend that makes every Puerto Rican dish taste like home.

- The master recipe, step by step
- Every ingredient explained + mainland swaps
- The 20-minute batch plan for a month of flavor
- Storage, shelf life & troubleshooting
- What one cube unlocks — a whole table of dishes

WHY IT MATTERS

One blend, a whole cuisine

Sofrito is the soul of Puerto Rican cooking. Before the rice hits the pot, before the meat goes in the pan, sofrito is there — frying gently until the kitchen smells like the island. Master it once, and every dish you cook after it starts a step ahead. In the Ortiz family kitchen, no dish ever started without it.

The ingredients, explained

Culantro (recao)

THE BACKBONE

Long, narrow-leafed herb with the unmistakable boricua perfume. This is what separates sofrito from a salsa verde.

Swap:

2 parts cilantro + a little green bell pepper.

Ajíes dulces

SWEET, NO HEAT

Tiny, fruity chiles that taste green and sweet. They round out the flavor without burning anyone.

Swap:

extra green bell pepper — add heat later if you like it.

Green & red bell pepper

COLOR + SWEETNESS

Bulk, body and a gentle sweetness. Both colors, not just one, for depth.

Swap:

any sweet pepper works in a pinch.

Yellow onion

DEPTH

The aromatic that everything else builds on. Keep it raw and punchy in the blend.

Swap:

white onion — slightly sharper.

Garlic

PUNCH

Never optional. A full head keeps the base assertive enough to season a whole pot of rice.

Swap:

2 tbsp jarred minced garlic if you must.

Olive oil

THE BINDER

Carries the flavors, keeps the blend lush, and protects it in the freezer.

Swap:

any neutral oil — you lose a little richness.

White vinegar

BRIGHTNESS + SHELF LIFE

A few tablespoons brighten everything and help the base keep longer.

Salt

THE LOUDSPEAKER

Turns all those flavors up. Taste the blend and adjust — your garlic is not my garlic.

Swap:

lime juice — just note it will shorten fridge life.

Swap:

fine sea salt, not table salt.

Fresh beats everything. If you can find culantro and ajíes dulces at a Latino grocer, buy them — they are the difference between “really good salsa” and sofrito.

Sofrito Base

Recaito — la base de todo

Yield: ~2 cups **Prep:** 20 min **Stores:** 2–3 weeks fridge / 3 months frozen

INGREDIENTS

1 bunch culantro (recao) or 2 bunches cilantro

15 ajíes dulces (or 1 extra green bell pepper)

2 green bell peppers, seeded

1 red bell pepper, seeded

1 large yellow onion

1 head garlic (10–12 cloves), peeled

½ cup olive oil

2 tbsp white vinegar

1 tbsp salt

METHOD

- 1** Wash everything. Rough-chop the herbs, peppers and onion; smash the garlic.
- 2** Pulse the sturdier items first — peppers, onion, garlic — then add the herbs.
- 3** Blend in short pulses until coarse and saucy. **Not a purée** — you want texture.
- 4** Stir in the oil, vinegar and salt. Taste and adjust the salt.
- 5** Pack into a clean jar, cover with a thin layer of olive oil, and cap it.
- 6** Refrigerate up to 3 weeks, or freeze in cubes for the month ahead.

Pro tip: pulse, rest, pulse. Over-blending heats the base and turns it brown; a coarse, bright-green sofrito is the goal.

VERSIÓN EN ESPAÑOL

Lava y pica el recaio, los ajíes, pimientos, cebolla y ajo. Procesa en pulsos hasta que quede una pasta gruesa y brillante — no un puré. Mezcla con el aceite, vinagre y sal, ajusta la sal, y guarda en frasco con una capa de aceite encima. 2–3 semanas en la nevera, o congelado en cubitos hasta 3 meses.

MAKE IT ONCE, USE IT ALL MONTH

The 20-Minute Batch Plan

Quintuple the recipe, fill two ice-cube trays, and a month of dinners is already seasoned. Here’s the math:

Ingredient	Single batch (~2 cups)	Month batch (~28 cubes)
Culantro / cilantro	1 bunch	5 bunches
Ajíes dulces	15	75 (or 5 green bell peppers)
Green + red bell pepper	2 + 1	10 + 5
Onion	1 large	5 large
Garlic	1 head	5 heads
Olive oil	½ cup	2½ cups
Vinegar	2 tbsp	⅔ cup
Salt	1 tbsp	5 tbsp

1 — Prep

Wash and rough-chop everything into processor-sized chunks. Big is fine, uniform is nicer.

2 — Blend in waves

Work in three or four batches so nothing overheats. Pulse each until coarse, then combine.

3 — Cube it

Spoon into ice-cube trays, smooth the tops, and freeze solid — about 3–4 hours.

4 — Bag it

Pop out the cubes into labeled freezer bags. 28 cubes ≈ 28 dinners. Write the date on the bag.

Cube math: one standard cube is exactly enough to season one pot of rice or guiso. Grab from the freezer straight into a hot pan — no thawing.

KEEP IT AT ITS BEST

Storage & Shelf Life

Where	How long	How to store
Fridge (jar)	2–3 weeks	Clean jar, a thin layer of oil on top, lid on.
Freezer (cubes)	Up to 3 months	Pop frozen cubes into a labeled zip bag.
Frozen cube → pan	No thawing	Straight into the hot oil or sofrito step.
Signs it's past its prime	Trust your nose	Off smell, gray-brown color, or fuzzy patches — toss it.

Troubleshooting

It tastes bitter

Usually the white pith and seeds from the bell peppers.

Fix: add a splash of vinegar and a pinch of sugar; next time, seed the peppers well.

It's watery

Not enough oil, or it was blended to a mush.

Fix: stir in a little more oil; pulse less next batch.

It went brown instead of green

Over-processing heated it up.

Fix: short pulses with pauses, and work in smaller batches.

It tastes flat

Your garlic and salt are doing the heavy lifting.

Fix: add a clove of garlic and a pinch more salt, pulse once, retaste.

It's weeping in the jar

Oil separating on top is normal — not a failure.

Fix: stir it back in before each scoop.

Too mild, no spark

Swaps muted the ají dulce & culantro.

Fix: a pinch of habanero or extra garlic gives it life.

Rule of thumb: taste it raw. Sofrito should be bright, garlicky, and slightly herbal — if it tastes right from the spoon, it will cook right.

YOUR NEXT STEP

One cube unlocks a full table

You now own the base of the whole cuisine. Each of these starts the same way — sofrito frying in oil — then runs with it:

Arroz con Pollo

Yellow chicken & rice, the Sunday classic

Arroz con Gandules

The #1 searched boricua rice

Habichuelas Guisadas

Stewed beans over white rice

Pollo Guisado

Stewed chicken with potato & calabaza

Picadillo

Savory ground beef — stuffing & plates

Sancocho

The root-vegetable stew of Sundays

These six — and 24 more — live in the full cookbook, each in English & Spanish, with the ingredient finder, pantry checklist, and a holiday menu builder.

BUEN PROVECHO

You just learned the hard part.

Everything else is a pot of rice away. Here's the full table when you're ready:

La Mesa Boricua — the full 30-recipe cookbook	\$47
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The Kitchen Bundle — cookbook + printables	\$67
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The Full Table — cookbook + weeknights system	\$97
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Mofongo & More — the 6-week course	\$197
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Keep an eye on your inbox — next freebie: **Coquito Season — 3 Holiday Recipes.**

Hecho con corazón y sofrito. — con amor, de la cocina Ortiz.